‘We have freed all the imperial slaves who exceed hundreds and thousands’, said Akbar. ‘To count as my slaves those whom I have captured by force means stepping outside the realm of justice and discernment.’ ‘From that day on,’ added Abu’l Fazl, ‘his majesty, nurtured by divine knowledge, styled his slaves chelas.’ Those former slaves who wished to leave were allowed to do so and those that remained would be given wages and duties to perform according to their capabilities. No mention, however, was made of the female slaves who, it might be assumed, remained sequestered. Akbar then asked his closest courtiers to also think on the matter and to suggest one meaningful measure that would be beneficial for the empire and its people. Prince Salim, thirteen years old now, and perhaps most aware of his father’s own feelings, suggested that children younger than twelve not be allowed to marry. Akbar was pleased with this suggestion and issued orders for its implementation. Raja Todar Mal, Raja Birbal, Faizi, Abdur Rahim, the physician Hakim Abul Fath, and Aziz Koka were some of the noblemen included in the deliberations and they all suggested various measures designed to improve the well-being of the most deserving and vulnerable.

In the course of this year there would be provocative experiments and changes at Fatehpur Sikri that would be talked about and recorded by the visitors at court. It was noted by all that Akbar now began his day in a most unusual manner. At the highest point of the roof of the palace, Akbar had had a wooden building ‘of ingenious workmanship’ constructed and from this building, in the cool and watchful dawn, Akbar worshipped the rising sun. For Badauni, it was clear that it was ‘the accursed Birbal’ who had convinced the Padshah:

> …that since the sun gives light to all, and ripens all grain, fruits and products of the earth, and supports the life of mankind, therefore that luminary should be the object of worship and veneration; that the face should be turned towards the rising and not towards the setting (towards Mecca) sun…that man should venerate fire, water, stones and trees, and all natural objects, even down to cows and their dung.

In the evenings, when all the lamps and the candles were lit, the whole court ‘had to rise up respectfully’. This Badauni attributed to an equally nefarious influence—Akbar’s Rajput wives. ‘From early youth, in